VATSIM MIAMI ARTCC

OFFICE OF THE ATM

ZMA ADMIN DIRECTIVE 1G

Effective: 10/02/2023

SUBJ: vZMA ARTCC Standard Operating Procedures

This document outlines all our policies, expectations, and processes. Please feel free to contact us at any time if you have questions regarding the content of this document. Welcome to Miami, we are glad to have you!

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

1. PURPOSE 2
2. CANCELLATION 2
3. TERMINOLOGY 2
4. GENERAL TRAINING POLICIES 4
5. TRANSFER/VISITING CONTROLLER TRAINING 5
6. REQUESTING TRAINING 6
7. TRAINING SESSIONS 6
8. SOLO CERTIFICATIONS 7
9. OVER-THE-SHOULDER (OTS) EVALUATIONS 8
10. QUALITY ASSURANCE (QA) 8
11. ARTCC STAFF ROLES & RESPONSIBILITIES 9
12. TRAINING STAFF POSITIONS & REQUIREMENTS 10
13. ADMINISTRATIVE POLICIES 11
14. EVENT POLICIES 12
15. GENERAL CONTROL 13
16. SATELLITE AIRPORT GROUPS REFERENCE 16

1. PURPOSE

This document lays out the fundamental rules, regulations, and operation of the VATSIM Miami ARTCC. All items contained in this document shall take precedence over all other ZMA documents unless explicitly specified otherwise. Any provision of this document may be temporarily overridden by the authority of the Air Traffic Manager as the situation dictates.

2. CANCELLATION

This document replaces and cancels ZMA Directive 1, Version E, dated as effective on 04/16/2022.

3. TERMINOLOGY

Below are common terms used throughout this document and their definitions, for your reference.

3.1. Adjacent Controller - A controller is considered to be adjacent to another when they are providing control services no more than one level (eg. TWR to APP) away. Remember that center also provides top-down service for any control positions not covered by other ZMA controllers.

3.2. Cab Control Position - As in the "cab" of a control tower, this includes the positions of Clearance Delivery, Ground Control and Local Control.

3.3. "Certification" - An approval for an individual to control a particular position online.

3.4. GRP Competency Check - A special type of evaluation intended to verify a controller has all the knowledge, skills, and abilities that their VATSIM rating indicates they should have. This is common with visiting/transfer controllers.

3.5. Instructor - An individual, authorized by the TA, and VATUSA, who performs training functions and additional duties (at the ARTCC or division level), who possesses an I1+ rating.

3.6. Local Control - "Local" is what controllers call the "Tower" position.

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3.7. "May" or "Need Not" - Indicates the procedure is optional.

3.8. Mentor - An individual authorized by the TA to provide training, but does not have an I1+ rating.

3.9. Mentor-in-Training – An individual training to become a Mentor, who is always paired with a certified trainer during training sessions.

3.10. MTS ("Monitored Training Session") - On-network training session in which the trainer staffs a control position one level directly above the trainee to generate additional traffic for them. See Section 4.4 on page 4 for more information.

3.11. Rating Upgrade - An increase in a controller's VATSIM rating.

3.12. Sectorization - The configuration of which sector(s) are currently combined at a given facility.

3.13. "Shall" or "Must" - Indicates the procedure is mandatory.

3.14. "Should" - Indicates the procedure is recommended, but not mandatory.

3.15. TMI ("Traffic Management Initiative") - A restriction or delay program issued by the TMU which serves to limit, reroute, or otherwise adjust the flow of traffic through ZMA airspace.

3.16. TMU ("Traffic Management Unit") - Manages traffic flow on a large scale, and makes use of TMIs to ensure a safe and efficient flow of traffic throughout ZMA airspace.

3.17. Trainer - Includes Mentors, Instructors, and Mentors-in-Training.

3.18. ZMA Primary Airports - KMIA, KFLL, KTPA, KSRQ, KPBI, KRSW, KEYW

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4. General Training Policies

4.1. Many "Training Program" documents have been created for each control position on which you will receive training. They contain the discussion points, lists of expectations and competencies, and any preparations you will need to complete outside of your training sessions. Please refer to the relevant Training Program when you have questions on what comes next in the training process.

4.1.1. Many Training Program documents contain a VATUSA-approved Rating Consolidation time. This is the time that you must log on the live network with each rating, before you become eligible to begin training for the next rating. This time should be used to practice and enhance your skills.

4.1.2. All Training Program documents can be found here.

4.2. No individual may officially train[1] a trainee without direct and explicit authorization from the TA.

4.3. All exams are taken on the VATUSA Academy, and are to be considered to be "open book".

4.3.1. In the event of failure of a VATUSA Written Examination, those examinations are usually automatically re-assigned within 7 days.

4.3.2. In the event of repeated failure of an exam, the TA may require the trainee to attend additional training session(s), or to complete a write-up of the questions they got wrong, to include the correct answers, and a source where that answer can be found.

4.4. Monitored Training Session - To hopefully generate additional traffic, trainers may elect to conduct an MTS, in which they can provide training to a trainee while simultaneously staffing a position only one level directly above the trainee[2]. The trainer must be able to continuously monitor the trainee. This shall not be applied with the trainer staffing any center position, therefore the trainee in question must be pursuing Tower or lower for an MTS to be possible.

4.5. Individuals who possess real-world Air Traffic Control experience may email ta@zmaartcc.net for consideration for expedited/abbreviated training. Decisions on specialized training plans are at the sole discretion of the TA.

[1] Providing tips or tricks is not considered training.
[2] For example, a trainee on Miami Ground with a trainer on Miami Tower is acceptable, but the trainer could not staff Miami Approach, because this is two levels away from Miami Ground, nor could they staff Fort Lauderdale Tower, because that would not be "directly above".

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5. Transfer/Visiting Controller Training

5.1. Controllers wishing to visit or transfer to ZMA, from a division outside of VATUSA, must first pass the VATUSA Rating Competency Exam (RCE) which corresponds to their rating. In accordance with VATUSA Division Training Policy, individuals who fail this Rating Competency Exam cannot be accepted into ZMA.

5.2. All controllers, regardless of VATSIM rating, transferring to or visiting ZMA shall complete the "Miami ARTCC Tower Trainee (S1)" course on the VATUSA Academy, and submit their course completion certificate to training@zmaartcc.net, prior to submitting any training availability. No training or GRP Competency Check will be scheduled until the course completion certificate is received by the Training Department.

5.3. For controllers holding a Tower Trainee (S1) rating, typically, no control position certifications are granted upon arrival. Training is required before any certifications will be granted.

5.4. Controllers holding a Tower Controller (S2) rating or higher must be able to demonstrate all competencies listed within Chapter 3 of the VATUSA Division Training Policy. To this end, prior to any control position certifications being issued at ZMA, these controllers shall schedule and pass a GRP Competency Check for their rating[3]. Request this session as outlined in Section 6.2.

5.5. Controllers who receive a rating upgrade while visiting shall not be entitled to exercise the privileges of their upgraded rating until all the following have been completed:

5.5.1. Log at least 50 hours on the live network, on a position at your home facility, at the highest level your new rating allows[4]. This is called "rating consolidation", and is a requirement dictated by VATUSA General Division Policy, Section 12.1.

5.5.2. When rating consolidation is completed, request a GRP Competency Check session, in accordance with the process outlined in Section 6.2 and 6.3 on page 6 below. Receive a passing result.

5.5.2.1. Upon passing the GRP Competency Check, ZMA management shall grant the controller full privileges of their upgraded rating promptly. Note that, per Section 13.2 (page 11), the controller must still not utilize these controlling privileges until they are reflected on the Controller Roster.

[3] Except where explicitly approved otherwise by the TA.
[4] For example, if you were just promoted to S2, you must log 50 hours on a TWR position at your home facility.

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6. REQUESTING TRAINING

6.1. Prior to requesting training on a new position, controllers shall:

6.1.1. For minor positions: Meet the rating advancement criteria per the relevant Training Program document, then request enrollment in the next VATUSA Rating Course[5] by emailing training@zmaartcc.net with your CID. **Pass the course exam before requesting training**.

6.1.2. For major positions: The only prerequisite to beginning training is to hold the underlying minor certification. No exams or other preparations are necessary, though you should be familiar with all relevant content in the appropriate SOP document.

6.2. Controllers shall create and manage training requests through the ZMA website at the following URL: https://zmaartcc.net/dash/training.

6.2.1. Requesting training directly from a trainer (via TeamSpeak, Discord, etc.) is never appropriate. Such requests will likely be ignored and may result in disciplinary action.

6.3. Trainees shall keep the times listed in their training requests up to date at all times. If a trainee is no longer available for a requested time, the trainee must update or cancel their requests accordingly. Repeated failure to do so may result in disciplinary action.

6.3.1. Please note that, due to trainer availability, it is possible that your training request might not be picked up. If this happens, just submit a new training request with updated availability. Continue to do so until a trainer accepts your training request. Delays of up to two weeks are normal. Only if the delay is longer than this, you may reach out to the TA to attempt to mitigate the scheduling issue.

6.4. Note that trainees with no certifications are required to submit frequent training requests in order to remain in compliance with ZMA's controller activity requirements. See Section 13.3.2 on page 11 for details.

7. TRAINING SESSIONS

7.1. Prior to any training session, trainees shall review and complete all applicable prerequisite tasks, as listed in the relevant Training Program documents, as well as any additional tasks assigned by a trainer.

7.2. All training sessions shall be conducted using the ZMA TeamSpeak. Trainers may (and often do) use additional means of delivering content to trainees, such as Discord screen share.

7.3. Trainers and trainees shall be present 5 minutes before their training session's scheduled start time.

7.3.1. Trainers may cancel the scheduled training session if the trainee is not present 10 minutes after the scheduled start time.

7.3.2. Trainees who fail to appear for scheduled training sessions two or more times shall not receive any further training until explicitly approved by the TA.

7.4. Additional trainees are authorized to observe training sessions, as long as they have the approval of both the trainer and the trainee.

7.4.1. Trainees observing a training session shall not actively participate, except as specified by the trainer.

7.4.2. Observing a training session does not count as receiving training, either in terms of activity requirements, or in terms of training session completion.

[5] Note that rating exams are only available for 30 days following the completion of all VATUSA course material.

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7.5. Trainees shall accept all critiques from trainers in a receptive and professional manner.

7.5.1. If a trainee believes that a trainer was not professional during their session, they should contact the TA within 24 hours of the session with a detailed complaint.

7.6. Trainees may find copies of training reports for all training sessions on the ZMA website under "Controller Dashboard → Training Sessions", as well as on the VATUSA website, under "My VATUSA → Profile → Training Records".

7.7. During training, if a controller is found to be deficient in any GRP competencies for ratings already held, they shall receive remedial training to address those deficiencies, prior to continuing any other training.

7.7.1. Visitors can expect to be referred back to their home facility for this remedial training.

7.8. Trainers may elect to host a theory-only session with up to 2 students who are working toward the same rating/certification. Trainers may also coordinate, amongst themselves, to hold training sessions at a mutual time which allows students to practice coordination and other controller-to-controller functions that may be otherwise difficult to simulate.

8. SOLO CERTIFICATIONS

8.1. Solo certifications are available to any ZMA home or visiting controller who already holds an S1 rating or higher[6].

8.2. Trainers are encouraged to issue trainees a solo certification when they believe the trainee will benefit from online exposure and experience, and possesses the skills to manage working the position without supervision.

8.3. Solo certifications are valid for 4 weeks from the date they are issued.

8.3.1. Solo certifications may be extended for an additional 4 weeks by instructors only (not by mentors[7]).

8.4. Trainees shall not utilize a solo certification until the solo certification is displayed on the ZMA Roster[8].

8.4.1. Minor Approach solos for S2 controllers must also be displayed on the VATUSA Solo Page[9].

8.4.2. Miami Center (Domestic) solos for S3 controllers must also be displayed on the VATUSA Solo Page.

8.5. Solo certifications shall not be granted for Miami Oceanic[10].

[6] Solo certifications can be given for all control positions unless specifically stated otherwise in this document. For example, an S1 on minor delivery, an S2 on Miami Tower or minor approach, an S3 or C1 on Miami Center, etc.
[7] A mentor may submit a request to extend a trainee's solo certification via the (staff-only) "solo-issuances" channel of the ZMA discord, where it will be reviewed by an instructor, who will take the appropriate action.
[8] The ZMA roster is available here: https://www.zmaartcc.net/controllers
[9] The VATUSA Solo Page is available here: https://www.vatusa.net/info/solo
[10] This is due to the nature of the shared use airspace program with the Nassau FIR. For ZMA controllers pursuing a Miami Oceanic certification, they must undergo the required ZMO and Nassau training, and earn a full certification directly without any solo certification opportunities.

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9. OVER-THE-SHOULDER (OTS) EVALUATIONS

9.1. An Over-the-Shoulder (OTS) Evaluation must be specifically scheduled as such. Training sessions may not be converted to an Over-the-Shoulder (OTS) Evaluation.

9.2. For *rating advancement* Over-the-Shoulder Evaluations:

- 9.2.1. The purpose of this OTS is to verify that a trainee meets VATSIM Global Ratings Policy (GRP), VATUSA Division Training Policy, and ZMA policy standards.
- 9.2.2. A rating advancement OTS shall only be conducted by an instructor, who shall immediately:
  - 9.2.2.1. On the ZMA website, complete a thorough training report.
  - 9.2.2.2. On the VATUSA website, complete the appropriate VATUSA Rating Review Form via the Promotion Submission Page.
- 9.2.3. These evaluations shall be scored using the applicable VATUSA Rating Review form.
- 9.2.4. If a trainee fails to meet established standards, they must complete at least one more training session before attempting another OTS Evaluation, unless otherwise approved by the TA.

9.3. For *major certification* Over-the-Shoulder Evaluations:

- 9.3.1. The purpose of this OTS is to verify that a trainee meets performance expectations, as outlined in the relevant major certification Training Program document, while remaining in full compliance with all ZMA directives.
- 9.3.2. A major certification OTS may be conducted by any trainer, who shall immediately:
  - 9.3.2.1. On the ZMA website, complete a thorough training report.

10. QUALITY ASSURANCE (QA)

10.1. With the amount of information contained within all ATC documents, ZMA has acknowledged the benefit from refresher training and improvement within our ARTCC. Various supplemental classes are made available on a semi-regular basis, in order to strengthen our controllers' knowledge, skills, and abilities. Unless otherwise communicated by the TA, these classes are optional and unscored.

10.2. ZMA Trainers are authorized to provide feedback on any home or visiting controller, on any position(s) for which the Trainer is certified[11], either directly to the controller, or to the Training Department, or both. Corrective feedback given to the controller should usually be candid and informal, on an as needed basis. The Training Department may document and securely store all such feedback and/or notes.

10.3. At the sole discretion of the TA, competency issues[12] observed by the Training Department may result in mandatory remedial training, and/or a temporary revocation of the relevant certifications until the remedial training is completed and proper competency is observed. The TA will develop the remedial training plan in coordination with VATUSA.

[11] Note: VATSIM Rating is not relevant in this instance, only position certification(s). For example, an S2 Trainer could monitor a controller on CTR and provide them with corrective feedback on TWR, GND, and DEL concepts.
[12] As outlined by the VATSIM Global Ratings Policy or the VATUSA Division Training Plan

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11. ARTCC STAFF ROLES & RESPONSIBILITIES

11.1. Air Traffic Manager (ATM) - Appointed and removed by VATUSA, reports to VATUSA Deputy Director of Air Traffic Services (VATUSA2), and is responsible for the overall administration of the ARTCC, its staff, and its controllers.

11.2. Deputy Air Traffic Manager (DATM) - Appointed and removed by ATM, reports to ATM. Acts as ATM in their absence, and assists ATM with assigned duties, including management of visiting and home controller rosters.

11.3. Training Administrator (TA) - Appointed and removed by ATM with concurrence of VATUSA Training Director (VATUSA3), reports equally to ATM and VATUSA3, and is responsible for development and management of the training program. Coordinates with FE regarding maintenance of training software and scenarios, and is responsible for selection and quality of training staff, including working with trainers to help them develop their knowledge, skills, and effectiveness as trainers.

11.4. Deputy Training Administrator (DTA) - Appointed by TA with concurrence of ATM, removed by either TA or ATM. Reports to TA, and acts as TA in their absence. Performs duties as assigned by TA.

11.5. Event Coordinator (EC) - Appointed and removed by ATM, reports to DATM, and is responsible for development, promotion, coordination, and advertising regarding facility events. Acts as a liaison between virtual airlines, other ARTCCs, and other external entities as necessary to ensure regular and successful events. Oversees event signups, position assignments, and the event briefing and debriefings.

11.6. Assistant Event Coordinator (AEC) - Appointed by EC, with concurrence of ATM, removed by either EC or ATM. Reports to EC, and acts as EC in their absence. Performs duties as assigned by EC.

11.7. Facility Engineer (FE) - Appointed and removed by ATM, reports to DATM, and is responsible for maintaining radar client files, SOPs, LOAs, and reference documentation. Coordinates with TA regarding maintenance of training software and scenarios. Also acts as a technical advisor regarding airspace, flight simulation, and scenery issues which affect the operation of our control positions.

11.8. Assistant Facility Engineer (AFE) - Appointed by FE, with concurrence of ATM, removed by either FE or ATM. Reports to FE, and acts as FE in their absence. Performs duties as assigned by FE.

11.9. Webmaster & IT Specialist (IT) - Appointed and removed by ATM, reports to DATM, and is responsible for maintaining the ARTCC website, forums, TeamSpeak, and any other technical services.

11.10. Assistant Webmaster & IT Specialist (AIT) - Appointed by IT, with concurrence of ATM, removed by either IT or ATM. Reports to IT, and acts as IT in their absence. Performs duties as assigned by IT.

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12. TRAINING STAFF POSITIONS & REQUIREMENTS

12.1. Becoming a Mentor-in-Training

12.1.1. The TA alone can review and decide upon applications for Mentor-in-Training.

12.1.2. To qualify to become a Mentor-in-Training, one must be an active ZMA home controller holding an S1 rating or higher, have no disciplinary history throughout VATSIM within the past two years, be of good moral character, demonstrate patience and empathy with controllers/trainees, and demonstrate good judgment and methodical tendencies.

12.1.3. Individuals interested in becoming a Mentor shall submit a statement of interest to the TA.

12.1.4. Each Mentor-in-Training shall be paired with a specific, current, certified trainer, and undergo the "Train the Trainer" course with them.

12.1.5. Only when directly supervised by their assigned trainer, a Mentor-in-Training may take the lead on teaching the trainee.

12.2. Becoming a Mentor

12.2.1. The TA alone can promote a controller to Mentor.

12.2.2. In addition to meeting the Mentor-in-Training qualifications, through their ARTCC interactions and the Train-the-Trainer program, applicants must demonstrate competency up to their controller rating (via a GRP Competency Check), competency and compliance with ZMA local policies and procedures (particularly Section 12.4 below), patience and empathy with trainees, thorough methodical, thorough, and effective training methods, and good judgement on when not to bother the trainee.

12.2.3. Promotion from Mentor-in-Training is the only way to become a Mentor. This will require enough supervised training sessions to demonstrate effectiveness as a trainer.

12.3. Becoming an Instructor

12.3.1. Applicants must be an active controller and Mentor, meeting activity requirements for both roles for the past 3 months, with no disciplinary history on VATSIM within the past two years. Activity level in the Mentor position is a major contributor to promotion to Instructor.

12.3.2. Applicants shall submit a statement of interest to the TA, via email, including why they are interested in the position, why it's important that they be appointed, and what type of instructor they want to be.

12.3.2.1. Prior to submitting a statement of interest to the TA, the interested candidate shall review the Probationary Instructor requirements and Instructor requirements, as outlined in the VATUSA Division Training Plan.

12.4. Trainer Expectations

12.4.1. All ZMA trainers shall conduct themselves in a professional manner at all times. Additionally, trainers should routinely check their ZMA email, and when necessary, respond to emails or discord messages from controllers or staff within 48 hours.

12.4.2. All ZMA trainers shall provide trainees with professional critique and knowledge to enhance the trainee's skills and proficiency on a position, or within a specific topic, but must be respectful and patient at all times. Any condescension, beratement, raising of the voice, or even excessive talking over the trainee will not be tolerated.

12.4.3. All training sessions shall be documented, via the ZMA website within 24 hours of completing the training session.

12.4.4. All ZMA trainers have the right to refuse training to individuals with documented cases of disrespect, insubordination, or repeated failures to show up to training appointments. The Training Department is still responsible to provide availability of training, and it will be up to the TA to ensure the trainee in question is still able to procure training time.

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12.4.5. Trainers may provide training "to their comfortability and within their ratings/certifications". No minimum time exists after a new certification before that trainer may provide training for that position, but you may wish to become comfortable on that position before agreeing to train someone else on it.

12.4.6. When conducting training on the live network, Mentors shall use a callsign of "XXX_M_XXX" and Instructors shall use "XXX_I_XXX". This includes when conducting a Monitored Training Session.

12.5. Trainer Activity Requirements

12.5.1. Trainer activity may be audited at any time.

12.5.2. Every calendar month, trainers not on LOA should log at least 3 training sessions[13], each of at least 30 minutes duration.

12.5.2.1. The TA may elect to waive activity requirements for a trainer when deemed appropriate.

12.5.3. Trainers on Leave of Absence (LOA) are exempt from the above activity requirements for the LOA period. They may continue to train when able, but shall not be held to reach the specified number of hours during the LOA period. All nonconsecutive LOAs of 6 months or less shall be automatically approved, and the trainer need only notify the TA.

13. ADMINISTRATIVE POLICIES

13.1. ZMA Directives - All members of ZMA shall comply with all provisions of all ZMA documents labeled as "directives". When staffing a controller position within Miami ARTCC, the controller does so with the implied understanding that they are familiar with, and will comply with, the latest versions of all facility directives.

13.2. Authorization to Control - Controllers shall never control positions which the Roster Page of the ZMA website does not indicate them to be certified to work. The roster must be updated to reflect a recent certification before a controller may begin to utilize that certification. Controllers found on positions for which they are not certified shall receive a written warning for the first offense (at minimum) and shall face removal for the second.

13.3. Activity Requirements - The below activity requirements apply to all controllers on the ZMA roster (including visitors). For controllers joining ZMA after the 15th of a given month, the policies below do not apply until the following month of membership. Failure to comply with activity requirements may result in removal.

13.3.1. Controllers holding certifications for any control position shall log a minimum of 3 hours of control time on the network, in a rolling 30-day period.

13.3.2. Controllers without certifications to control any network position shall submit a minimum of 3 training requests on the ZMA website per calendar month.

13.3.3. Controllers who fail to maintain the required minimum level of activity may be removed at the discretion of the ATM, or their designee, and the controller shall be notified of this action.

13.3.4. ZMA retains the right to audit controller activity at any time.

13.4. Returning to ZMA - If a previous controller was removed for inactivity, and rejoins ZMA, the below apply.

13.4.1. A controller returning to ZMA within 6 months of their removal for inactivity shall have all previously held minor and major certifications restored (except solo certifications).

13.4.2. A controller returning to ZMA more than 6 months since their removal for inactivity shall have only minor certifications according to their rating. The TA (or their designee) shall determine which major certifications will be immediately restored, and which will require re-training.

[13] Here, "training sessions" also include monitored training sessions, network observation, and OTS Evaluations. All time logged on any of these activities count toward trainer activity requirements.

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13.5. Leave of Absence - Any member or staff member may request a leave of absence by request, in writing, to the ATM or DATM, detailing estimated length of leave and a brief reason. Requests greater than ninety days may require a conversation with the ATM to discuss options. Controllers on Leave of Absence shall not log onto any control position on the network until the Leave of Absence is lifted.

13.6. Behavioral Requirements

13.6.1. All members of ZMA must be respectful to one another, to staff, and to pilots. Repeated or significant violations of this requirement may result in suspension or removal.

13.6.2. Controllers shall never engage in conflicts with pilots. If a conflict exists, controllers shall contact a supervisor, and let them handle it. Continued back and forth with disagreeable pilots will not be tolerated, regardless of the pilot's behavior. Failure to remain professional may result in punitive action.

13.6.3. Controllers who demonstrate multiple (or single severe) instances of insubordination to ZMA staff, or who continually demonstrate a disruptive influence or attitude shall be referred to the Deputy Division Director for disciplinary action.

13.7. Network Feedback – Any negative feedback a controller receives while controlling on the network involving controller competency shall be forwarded to the TA for appropriate corrective action. At the sole discretion of the TA, this may be as simple as a short chat with the controller, or as involved as full remedial training.

13.8. Selection of ATC Client – Controllers may use any client approved for ATC use on VATSIM during controlling sessions or training sessions at ZMA. Controllers should understand that certain clients have a learning curve, and they will be held responsible for their level of performance, regardless of their choice of client.

14. EVENT POLICIES

14.1. Event Registration - If possible, controllers wishing to participate in advertised events should register with the ZMA website. Controllers are encouraged to show up even if they have not registered, but will not be guaranteed a control position.

14.2. Event Briefings - Controllers participating in an event shall arrive at least 30 minutes before the published start of the event for the event briefing in TeamSpeak. If unable to arrive on time to the briefing, the controller shall advise the EC as soon as possible.

14.3. Full Participation - If possible, controllers should make every attempt to be available for the entirety of an event they sign up to work. Controllers unable to work the entire event shall advise the EC as soon as possible, and at least 3 hours prior to the event's published start time. Controllers who have signed up for an event, who experience last minute changes to their availability shall advise the EC (or CIC in their absence) immediately. The EC must take all of the above into consideration when determining the sectorization/configuration to minimize the impact that the controller's mid-event departure or absence history could have on the event.

14.4. Priority Placement - Unless an operational need dictates otherwise (whether for traffic demand or personnel shortage), the EC shall give ZMA home controllers priority placement over visiting controllers.

14.5. Cooperation with Assigned Rostering - Controllers assigned a position for an event they've signed up for shall be cooperative with accepting the control position they've been assigned. Repeatedly declining to participate when dissatisfied with the assigned position may result in less favorable placement in future events, at the discretion of the EC.

14.6. Failing to Appear for an Event – When a controller signs up for an event, is assigned a position, and fails to appear on time to the event (and briefing), this may result in less favorable placement in future events, at the discretion of the EC.

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15. GENERAL CONTROL

15.1. Voice Coordination – All controllers actively controlling ZMA positions on the VATSIM network shall remain connected, unmuted, and continuously available for verbal coordination on the ZMA TeamSpeak for the duration of their controlling session. All Position Relief Briefings should be conducted by voice.

15.2. Observer Callsigns - The below callsigns shall be used on the network during observation. For policy regarding frequency monitoring, also see Section (15.10) below.

- 15.2.1. Controllers shall observe under the callsign "ZMA_XX_OBS", where "XX" represents their operating initials, as shown on the Roster Page.
- 15.2.2. ZMA Staff holding these positions may observe under the callsigns of "ZMA_ATM", "ZMA_DATM", "ZMA_TA", "ZMA_DTA", "ZMA_FE", "ZMA_AFE", "ZMA_EC", or "ZMA_AEC", as appropriate.
- 15.2.3. Trainers may observe under the callsigns "ZMA_XX_MTR", or "ZMA_XX_INS", as appropriate, where "XX" represents their operating initials, as shown on the Roster Page.

15.3. Voice vs. Text - Controllers shall never insist that communications must be conducted via voice. Every effort shall be made to ensure text and voice pilots receive equal service.

15.4. 30 Minute Courtesy - To the best of their ability, for the benefit of the pilots, controllers should try to keep any online session at a given position open for a minimum of 30 minutes. This is not a requirement, but rather a courtesy to the pilots, because they will frequently change their plans to seek out ATC.

15.5. Position Relief Briefings - Before assuming control for a position, controllers shall conduct a position relief briefing with any ZMA controllers working an "adjacent position". The controller may sign on with their intended callsign before beginning the briefing, but may not set a primary frequency or make any transmissions until the briefing is complete. The briefing shall include the following items at minimum:

- 15.5.1. Controllers - Other online controllers, and (if necessary) their sectorizations
- 15.5.2. Configurations - Current configuration of relevant ZMA Primary Airports, and/or KMCO/MUHA/etc.
- 15.5.3. Traffic - Pertinent information on traffic under our control

15.6. Automatic Releases - Unless otherwise coordinated in the position relief briefing, or otherwise dictated in a facility's SOP, Local Control is understood to have automatic releases with the controller providing departure services (whether APP, DEP, or CTR).

15.7. Current Wind Information – Issue current wind information in all runway clearances[14].

15.8. Longitudinal Departure Spacing – If divergence between successive departures is not applied, the local controller shall provide the departure controller with *double the applicable radar separation minima*[15].

15.9. Manual Runway Crossings - Unless otherwise coordinated in the position relief briefing, Ground Control is understood to need to manually coordinate runway crossings with Local Control on an individual basis.

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[14] "Runway clearances" include takeoff, landing, touch and go, low approach, stop and go, and option clearances.
[15] For example, large to large requires 3nm separation in a TRACON, meaning 2 departures with insufficient angular divergence shall be delivered at 3 x 2 = 6 miles in trail. Remember, from the start of takeoff roll to the initial climbout, you will gain about 2nm of space from the previous departure—so to achieve 6 miles in trail, the second departure should be rolling when the first is 4 miles ahead of them.

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15.10. Frequency Monitoring - Any ZMA controller may monitor the frequency of any other controller at any time. Neither permission from, nor notification to the monitored controller is required. The monitored controller shall not attempt to deny or prevent any other controller the right to listen to their frequency.

15.11. Handoffs - Radar Controllers shall initiate a transfer of radar identification of airborne aircraft at least 2 minutes prior to them entering the receiving controller's airspace. All controllers shall complete the transfer of communications with the aircraft prior to the aircraft crossing the boundary between the two controllers' areas of responsibility.

15.12. Altitude Assignment – Except where specified otherwise by local facility SOPs, Clearance Delivery shall ensure cruise altitudes are amended to be correct for direction of flight, as dictated by the magnetic bearing directly from origin airport to destination airport, ignoring any routing.

15.13. TMIs - All controllers shall comply with Traffic Management Initiatives (TMIs)[16] as initiated by the TMU or the affected control position.

15.14. Data Blocks - All controllers shall ensure data blocks are correct prior to initiating a radar handoff. This includes voice tags, altitudes (if applicable), scratchpads, etc.

15.15. Contact-Me & Wallop - All controllers shall send "contactme" messages no more frequently than one every 2 minutes. After three attempts, controllers should reduce this frequency further as appropriate. Controllers shall make a reasonable attempt to establish contact with aircraft before utilizing a "wallop" message.

15.16. VFR Departures – Clearance Delivery shall instruct all VFR departures to “maintain VFR at or below 2,500”. When traffic dictates, this restriction will be lifted by departure or local control, as appropriate. When easily known or obtained, record the below basic information about VFR aircraft, and store it in a VFR flight plan.

15.16.1. Type of Aircraft (equipment suffix not required)

15.16.2. Intended VFR Cruise Altitude

15.16.3. Direction of Flight, recorded in their route as "VFR NORTH", or appropriate direction

15.16.4. Optional: Place “REQ FF” or “NEG FF” in the *remarks* (not in the route), to indicate flight following status.

15.17. Temporary Altitudes - When center is online, TRACON shall enter the last altitude cleared to, before initiating a handoff to center. This altitude may be preloaded[17]. As an additional service, any cab control position may enter temporary altitudes in accordance with the altitude the aircraft are cleared to climb to, only if another controller is online providing departure control services. When requested by the controller providing departure control services, the cab controller shall stop entering temporary altitudes.

15.17.1. Controllers using vSTARS may disregard Section 15.17, since it will be removed on handoff automatically.

[16] Such as Miles-In-Trail (MIT), Minutes-In-Trail (MINIT), Ground Stop (GS), or Airborne Holding (HOLD)

[17] To "preload" a data block is to update it with information that has not yet taken place. In this example, you may enter a temporary altitude of 16,000 if you know a departure will be climbed to 16,000 and then handed off to center, even if you have not yet issued that climb. Normally, this is not allowed.

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15.18. Radar Tower Services – Radar tower services may only be provided by controllers holding S3 certifications with ZMA, at airports specifically indicated to provide "radar tower services" in that facility's SOP. In the absence of any of these, do not provide radar services of any kind. Otherwise, except as described below, Local Control may provide complete radar services, including radar identifying, tracking, initiating radar handoffs and point outs, clock/distance based traffic information, and (to a limited extent[18]) radar vectors.

15.18.1. Only start a track for aircraft which you have properly established positive radar identification, and called the aircraft "radar contact". If they descend below radar coverage, they will need to be re-identified. For this reason, it is not appropriate to track aircraft remaining in the traffic pattern.

15.18.2. Do not track IFR aircraft, except IFR overflights through LC assigned airspace.

15.18.3. Do not issue any approach clearances.

[18] Aircraft should only be vectored for sequencing or separation. For example, vectoring for traffic is acceptable, while vectoring for an approach, or in the traffic pattern, would not be acceptable.

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16. Satellite Airport Groups Reference

Group	Airport	Sub-Group
MIA	KTMB	
	KHST	
	X51	
	07FA	
FLL	KTNT	S
	KOPF	S
	HWO	S
	KFXE	N
	KPMP	N
TPA	KBKV	N
	KZPH	N
	X39	N
	KVDF	N
	KPCM	N
	KLAL	N
	X49	N
	KBOW	N
	KGIF	N
	KCLW	N
	KPIE	N
	KSPG	N
	KMCF	S
	KTPF	S
	KSRQ	S
	KVNC	S
PBI	KBCT	
	KLNA	
	F45	
	06FA	
	KPHK	
	X10	
	X58	
	KSUA	
	KFPR	
	KVRB	
	X52	
	X26	
RSW	KPGD	N
	FA54	N
	KFMY	N
	X14	N
	08FA	N
	KIMM	S
	KAPF	S
	FA37	S
	KMKY	S
MYNN	MYEH	
	MYAF	
	MYEM	
	MYER	

Group	Airport	Sub-Group
F11 (MCO)	KMLB	MLB
	KCOF	MLB
	X59	MLB
	KTIX	CANAVERAL
	KXMR	CANAVERAL
	KTTS	CANAVERAL
	KCOI	CANAVERAL
	X21	CANAVERAL
	KISM	
	KORL	
	KSFB	
	KLEE	
	X04	
	X23	
DAB	KEVB	
	KDED	
	KOMN	
	KFIN	
	X50	
JAX	KINF	VITTS
	KCGC	VITTS
	KOCF	VITTS
	X35	VITTS
	X60	VITTS
	KGNV	W
	42J	W
	28J	W
	KVQQ	W
	KNIP	W
	KHEG	W
	KNEN	W
	KSGJ	E
	KCRG	E
	KNRB	E
	KFHB	E
CENTRAL BAHAMAS	MYEF	
	MYEG	
	MYSM	
	MYAP	
	MYRP	
	MYAP	
	MYIG	
	MYMM	
MBPV	MBGT	
	MBAC	
	MBSC	
	MBNC	

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